

EU Drug Market: Drivers and facilitators — Globalisation



Globalisation is the process by which entities become globally interconnected through networks of communication, trade and transportation. This has a significant effect on illicit drug markets, as criminal networks exploit globalisation to achieve similar benefits to participants in the legal economy. Globalisation has provided significant opportunities for criminal cooperation, while also enabling cheaper, faster and more efficient criminal operations – as seen in the trafficking of large quantities of illicit drugs.

This resource is part of [EU Drug Market: Drivers and facilitators](#) by the EMCDDA and Europol.



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Criminal cooperation

Globalisation provides opportunities for criminal cooperation and integration along the supply chain, thus making operations more efficient. Drug trafficking stands out as one of the main activities of the most threatening criminal networks in the EU, with about half of the reported networks involved in this crime area (Europol, 2024a). The impact of globalisation on communication channels, specifically the process of digitalisation, has played a key role in enabling cooperation between criminal networks in Europe and globally (see Box [Digital cooperation](#)).

Greater interconnectedness between criminal networks has also boosted the emergence of key facilitators that provide their services to several different networks. Criminal ventures increasingly mirror licit business models, where partnerships are formed opportunistically based on business needs, while some services are outsourced to specialised criminal service providers. Ad hoc or more permanent partnerships are often established between different criminal networks, in which brokers or criminal service providers work together with individual criminals or groups tied to core criminal activities, such as drug trafficking. This has led to a serious and organised crime environment that is simultaneously characterised by fragmentation and networking, where profit is the main motivation for cooperation.

Digital cooperation

The digital transformation of our societies, economies and private lives is reflected in the operations of criminal networks. The internet and new technologies increasingly facilitate rapid communication between participants in drug exchanges and allow new models of criminal groups to develop and operate. Administrators of darknet markets and online vendors of illicit drugs illustrate a model of digital criminal cooperation (Leukfeldt et al., 2019). Other communication channels featuring end-to-end encryption, such as instant messaging applications, are also used by criminal networks for rapid communication, with reduced visibility to law enforcement (see Section [Encrypted communication](#)).

Services provided to drug-trafficking networks

The use of criminal service providers by drug-trafficking networks has become widespread in recent years. While some networks manage most of their operations independently, drug trafficking typically requires establishing fluid collaboration between networks, sharing responsibilities and outsourcing certain functions or even entire stages of the trafficking chain to specialised networks or individuals. In this context, crime-as-a-service provides flexibility to drug-trafficking networks in managing their illicit activities, which involve distinct stages and often span different countries or continents (see Box [Crime-as-a-service](#)). Services include transportation and logistics, supply chain management, waste disposal, provision of fraudulent documents (e.g. to facilitate the transportation of drugs or procurement of essential chemicals and equipment) and money laundering.

Crime-as-a-service

The increasing availability of knowledge, tools and expertise provided to criminal networks through crime-as-a-service, in which criminals use the services of other, more specialised criminals, has enabled a greater number of criminal networks to engage in multiple criminal activities despite lacking specific expertise or experience. The crime-as-a-service component also allows criminal networks involved in drug trafficking to be more geographically flexible and to optimise their business models by outsourcing specific activities to dedicated service providers.

More criminal individuals and networks offer a wider range of specialised services to other criminal networks, both offline and online (Roddy and Holt, 2020). For example, certain criminal networks are specialised in the management of the logistics and supply chains for drug producers in the European Union. Their specialised services include procurement of drug precursors and other chemicals required for drug production, and the provision of equipment or expertise needed to establish drug production facilities. Often, legal business structures are set up (or purchased) to access chemicals and to facilitate and conceal trafficking operations. Other service providers may include specialists who customise vehicles to conceal drugs, those who arrange the transportation of drug consignments to destination countries or IT specialists who manage and maintain the infrastructure for the online drugs trade.

Brokers are also present in all stages of criminal business operations and serve multiple criminal networks. They are essential in connecting these networks to each other and to criminal service providers. In the context of drug-trafficking operations, brokers connect drug producers to wholesale distributors, to transportation providers and to retail distributors. This may lead to a shift between or expansion of the range of drugs offered by certain networks (see Box [Poly-drug trafficking](#)). They also facilitate contact with other criminal specialists who provide firearms, fraudulent documents, chemicals, equipment and expertise for drugs production. Some brokers coordinate the movement of drugs consignments and facilitate money laundering, waste disposal and access to compromised individuals.

Poly-drug trafficking

Criminal networks involved in drug trafficking in the European Union are often involved in trading different types of drugs. While poly-drug trafficking has remained a very visible feature among mid-level suppliers and distributors, top-level criminal networks also traffic large-scale consignments that include more than one type of drug. Another aspect of the poly-drug nature of drug trafficking in Europe is the use of drugs and precursors as currency, occasionally seen in the form of drug swaps between criminal networks (for example, cannabis traded for heroin on the Balkan route in Türkiye).

Transportation and logistics

A key aspect of globalisation is the interconnectedness of global supply chains caused by the digitalisation of international logistics. The role played by information technology in checking and managing traffic flows at seaports and airports has increased the importance to criminals of having access to automated logistics systems. They may obtain such access through the corruption or cooperation of key staff, such as through bribes or extortion, and by hacking into computer networks or via publicly accessible databases (as both maritime and air traffic data are often publicly available). A recent assessment of the threat of infiltration of EU port infrastructure by organised crime highlighted the techniques that criminal networks use to exploit loopholes in logistical processes, such as misappropriating container reference codes to gain access to containers in which drugs are trafficked (known as PIN code fraud) (Europol and the Security Steering Committee of the ports of Antwerp, Hamburg/Bremerhaven and Rotterdam, 2023). In future, it is plausible that entire logistical chains will be automated, which may create the potential for exploitation by criminal networks (for example, if criminals are able to compromise one part of the system, they may then gain access to the whole logistical chain). Appropriate technological responses are therefore needed to mitigate these threats (see Box [Real-time vessel tracking capability developed by Frontex](#)).

Real-time vessel tracking capability developed by Frontex

The concept of 'connected' or 'smart containers' (electronic tracking of containers) provides opportunities to mitigate the threats posed by criminal networks that exploit containerised shipping. Using sensors, connected shipping containers provide real-time visibility of global cargo flows and indications of when, where and possibly why disruptions or delays have occurred (DHL, 2022). Connected containers thus have the potential to reduce the risk of criminal exploitation during transportation.

This concept has been operationalised by the European Border and Coast Guard Agency (Frontex), which has developed the Joint Operations Reporting Application (JORA): an information collection and analysis tool for tracking the itinerary of target vessels in real time. The tool is available to Member States upon request. It supports the authorities' operations by allowing them to track vessels suspected of carrying drugs and thus providing an accurate picture of the routes taken by traffickers from origin or transit areas to destination ports in Europe.

Maritime transportation

According to the UNODC, an estimated 90 % of the global cargo trade is transported by sea every year (amounting to over 750 million 20-foot equivalent units) ⁽¹⁾ (UNODC, date unspecified). Given that maritime transport is used in 77 % of EU external trade and 35 % of all trade by value between EU Member States, it forms a key part of the international supply chain. Despite a temporary dip in activity in 2020 due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the maritime transport sector continues to grow, fuelled by rising demand for primary resources and container shipping (EEA and EMSA, 2021).

The criminal exploitation of maritime routes continues to be a critical enabler of drug trafficking, as only a small fraction of shipping containers globally is screened. Large container ports in Europe and other continents continue to be exploited by drug traffickers for bulk transportation. In 2020, 72 % of the 609 drug detections made during Frontex-coordinated joint operations were reported at sea borders or adjacent areas (Frontex, 2021). As detailed in other EU Drug Markets resources (see [EU Drug Market: Cocaine](#)), most of the cocaine available on the EU market enters via the largest container ports in Europe, although increasingly, smaller ports are also utilised. Maritime routes have also risen in prominence for the trafficking of other drugs such as heroin (see [EU Drug Market: Heroin and other opioids](#)). Recently, large quantities of cannabis have also been trafficked in maritime containers to Europe, including from North America (see [EU Drug Market: Cannabis](#)). In August 2023, more than 1 tonne of cannabis was seized in Rotterdam from a container shipped from Canada (Openbaar Ministerie, 2023). These developments underscore how globalisation is erasing barriers between origin, transit and consumer destinations for illicit drug flows.

Factors affecting the maritime sector are likely to influence the global drug trade. For example, conflict, instability and economic pressures may lead to shifting supply routes, as already observed in the rise in heroin trafficking along the southern maritime route from Afghanistan to Europe (see

[EU Drug Market: Heroin and other opioids](#)). Such changes may in turn affect drug-trafficking routes, prices (and purities) along the supply chain, or lead to other routes or transportation methods being used to move drug consignments globally.

Diversification of maritime trafficking methods

In recent years, diversification has been observed in the methods used for maritime drug trafficking (see [EU Drug Market: Cocaine](#); see also Figure [Maritime trafficking: diversification of modi operandi](#)). Typically, drug traffickers operate front companies, which they establish themselves or preferably buy, becoming the owners of businesses with a history of legal activity. This enables them to conceal activities related to illicit drugs, such as purchasing equipment or moving funds, but crucially also to hide drug consignments in legitimate maritime shipments.

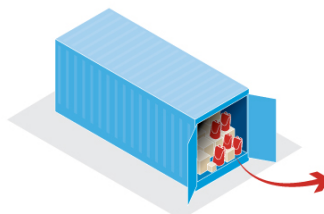
Alternatively, traffickers appropriate the containers of other companies and use them to transport large quantities of drugs. This is achieved by breaking open the containers before export, depositing the drugs inside and re-sealing the container with cloned seals to hide the tampering (known as rip-on/rip-off). In some cases, the containers are contaminated en route to the destination, in transshipment locations.

On arrival, the traffickers require access to the port to retrieve the stashed drugs from the containers. To do so, they may either trespass or pay port workers in order to obtain access. Corruption, as well as being a negative consequence of drug markets, is a key enabler of organised criminal activity – and opportunities for corruption exist at every stage of the drug supply chain.

Maritime trafficking: diversification of modi operandi

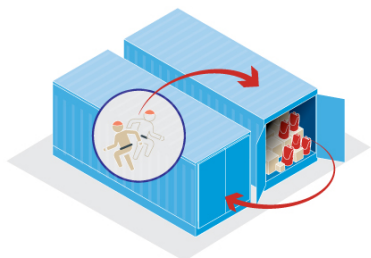
Rip-on/rip-off

Loading the drugs in the port of departure and recovering them in the port of destination, typically without the sender or the recipient of the legal cargo being aware their container is being used for drug-trafficking activities. Typically requires corruption in both ports.



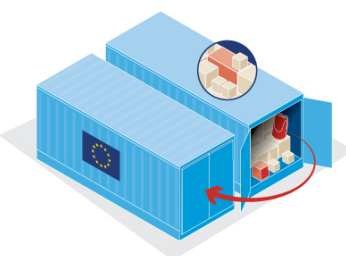
Trojan horse

A variation of the rip-off method involves one or more people, so-called 'cocaine extractors', being smuggled into a port hidden inside an empty container to retrieve cocaine concealed in other containers. The extractors wait inside the container to be informed via smartphone of the number and location of the container holding the cocaine that they are tasked with retrieving. The cocaine is extracted and placed in the previously empty container, which is subsequently retrieved from the port area. The 'Trojan horse' method has been used in multiple European ports.



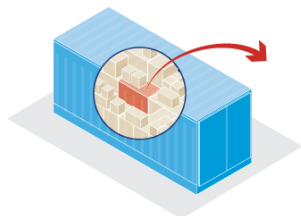
Switch

A variant of rip-on/rip-off, increasingly used in the EU. In the port of origin the drugs are placed in an easily accessible place in the container. At the EU destination port, before the container is inspected, corrupt dock workers retrieve the drugs and transfer them to a different container — either one that has already been cleared by customs or one that doesn't require inspection (e.g. intra-European transit). This requires involvement of port employees and either the transporter or receiver of the new container.



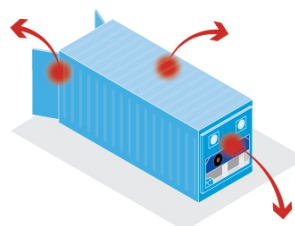
Within legitimate goods

Drugs are disguised as or incorporated into the legitimate goods. Typically this requires the involvement of the owners of the legal cargo, but can also involve a corrupt dock worker or others involved in the handling of the goods.



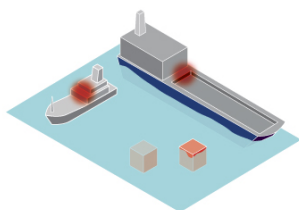
In container structure

Drugs are concealed in areas of the container such as cooling compartments, insulation materials within the walls and floorings or in the exterior beams. This method requires the involvement of corrupt port employees to place and retrieve the drugs.



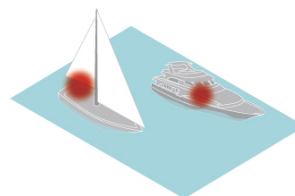
Commercial vessels and drop-off

Drugs can be transported by a range of commercial vessels such as cargo ships, fishing vessels, tankers and tugboats. Close to the destination, drugs can also be dropped off in the sea for collection.



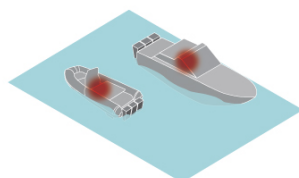
Pleasure vessels

Pleasure vessels such as yachts are frequently used, as checks on them are typically less stringent.



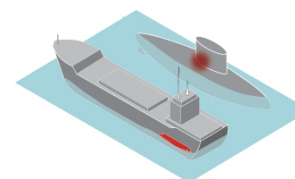
Inflatable and speed boats

Small vessels adapted or custom-made and powered with multiple outboard motors are used for the transportation of drug shipments over short to medium distances. Drugs are loaded and unloaded in remote areas. The vessels are fast enough to avoid detection or capture. They are extensively used in the Mediterranean Sea and Atlantic coastal waters.



Underwater attachments and semi-submersibles

Drugs are transported in missile-shaped containers attached to the hull of the vessels below the water. This method requires the use of specialised divers at both the origin and destination ports. Semi-submersible and submarine-type vessels are typically human-piloted, although unmanned crafts may be seen in future.



Civil aviation

In addition to maritime transport, air transport is also used for drug trafficking to and within the European Union. The two main categories of civil aviation used are scheduled air transport, including passenger and cargo flights operating on regular routes, and general aviation, which includes all other commercial and private flights. Detecting consignments of drugs trafficked via general aviation is particularly challenging as it is less regulated than scheduled air transport, and as a result there is limited opportunity to inspect air cargo. Criminal networks use general aviation, from small aircraft to business jets, for trafficking drugs making use of the services provided by skilled collaborators, mostly well-experienced pilots commissioned for ad hoc projects

Air cargo has become a key facilitator for the online trade, and this has also had an impact on drug trafficking. In 2021, air cargo represented a third of the revenue of International Air Transport Association member airlines, driven by an increase in demand and a decrease in passenger travel during the pandemic (IATA, 2021b). Estimates show that around 80 % of cross-border online trade (e-commerce) is transported by air (IATA, 2021a).

Criminal networks increasingly exploit the opportunities of air cargo services for drug trafficking by concealing drugs among legitimate cargo or within the airplane itself. An in-depth analysis of 16 cases from the Dutch Organised Crime Monitor found that traffickers use Amsterdam Airport Schiphol as a key logistical node by exploiting the infrastructure set up for legal economic activities (Madarie and Kruisbergen, 2020). In one case, a criminal group established a cleaning company at the airport to gain access to aircraft and IT systems (Madarie and Kruisbergen, 2020). The use of airports for drug trafficking can be likened to that of maritime ports, in terms of the mechanisms involved to evade security, for example by using corrupt employees or law enforcement agents. Differences in the way airports operate and their security arrangements, however, mean that criminal networks sometimes use different methods to those used in seaports.

Post and parcel services

Globalisation and digitalisation have paved the way for the expansion of express post and parcel delivery services, with the growing trend for online shopping associated with an increase in parcel deliveries in Europe (Eurostat, 2022; Statista, 2021). The overall quantity of drugs trafficked by these means remains limited compared with other forms of transportation (such as maritime and air traffic). Nevertheless, the increase in postal delivery volumes poses challenges for the systematic inspection of parcels and presents an opportunity for drug traffickers to traffic smaller quantities of drugs rapidly at global level. As a consequence, law enforcement authorities in EU Member States, and customs agencies in particular, have sought to increase checks in post and parcel hubs.

Criminals often conceal the origin and content of parcels by making false declarations and using fraudulent documents to circumvent risk indicators used to identify parcels for checks. To some degree, the identification of suppliers is also hampered by differences in regulatory frameworks and reporting between EU and non-EU postal systems and the use of parcel-forwarding services (see Box [Parcel-forwarding services](#)).

Parcel-forwarding services

Criminals use parcel-forwarding services to facilitate the trafficking of illicit commodities. In this method, postal companies may provide their clients with addresses in other jurisdictions, repack the parcels and guarantee international shipment to the final destination. This creates opportunities for criminals intending to conceal the origin, final destination and nature of illicit shipments. Since these companies do not usually open the packages, criminals can conceal the nature of the shipments by sending false customs declarations.

In particular, the postal system is often used for deliveries of online drug purchases (through social media, the surface web and darknet markets). This trend appears to have rapidly expanded and intensified during the COVID-19 pandemic. Examples from Germany and the Netherlands illustrate how criminals use this method, which affects all Member States, and a number of countries have reported considerable increases in letters and parcels containing drugs (see [Box Post and parcel seizures in Germany and the Netherlands](#)). The specific routing of parcels varies widely, including direct routes from source to destination or via EU transit hubs and non-EU locations.

Post and parcel seizures in Germany and the Netherlands

During checks of outgoing mail at the International Mail Centre in Frankfurt between September 2016 and the end of 2019, German Customs seized a total of around 28 500 letters containing approximately 2 000 kg of illicit drugs, including over 1.4 million MDMA tablets. These mail consignments were destined to over 90 different countries. At the end of 2019, Austria was ranked the second recipient destination (after the United States) for the seizures made in Frankfurt. The items destined for Austria contained over 240 kilograms of illicit drugs, mainly amphetamine and MDMA (BMI, 2021).

In 2020, Dutch Customs, in collaboration with the Public Prosecution Service, launched a programme of more rigorous checking of postal shipments. By mid-2021, the programme had resulted in the seizure of more than 8 000 packages and letters containing mainly synthetic drugs. More than 2 700 postal items contained MDMA; over 1 300 items contained cannabis products; and the rest contained a range of other substances, including cocaine, heroin, ketamine and LSD (Rijksoverheid, 2021). Illicit drugs produced in the Netherlands and purchased online are not only shipped directly from the country, but are often also dispatched by mail from neighbouring Belgium and Germany (National Police of the Netherlands, 2022).

Targeted screening, supported by artificial intelligence, can make it easier to identify postal items with illicit contents. Such measures can significantly disrupt the distribution of illicit drugs by this modus operandi. They can also help protect postal service staff from coming into contact with potentially dangerous substances. Dutch Customs, in partnership with PostNL and the police, are working to introduce algorithms in the scanning process to check mail more effectively in postal sorting centres (Rijksoverheid, 2021).

(1) A 20-foot equivalent unit represents the cargo capacity of a standard multimodal container.

References

Consult the list of [references](#) used in this module.

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